

English Ladder

Student Workbook

Few and Little with/without "a"

A polished self-study handout designed for print or tablet use. Read the concept, notice the pattern, and then complete the matching practice set on your own.



Grammar Concepts #	Key Points	Usage of "Few" and "A F	Usage of "Little" and "A L	Detailed Examples and Contexts
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Visual anchor

Use the concept poster to spotlight the main language pattern in **Few and Little with/without "a"** and keep the explanation visible during practice and discussion.

ENGLISH LADDER

Concept 27 ► Few & Little with/without "a"

Sometimes a single word can completely change the meaning of a sentence. Consider the inclusion or exclusion of **"a"** in the sentences in the green section.

It's enough!

It's not enough!

I have a few opportunities to speak English, so I am learning English faster than I expected.	I have few opportunities to speak English, so I am not learning English as fast as I expected.
I have a little cash, so I can buy lunch today.	I have little cash, so I cannot buy lunch today.

The word **"few"** is used with countable nouns while **"little"** is used with uncountable nouns.

a few	few	◀ Countable
a little	little	◀ Uncountable

When we think the amount is enough, we include the word **"a"** before **"few"** and **"little"**, but not when we think the amount is insufficient to do what we want.

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Core Idea

The words few and little can drastically change the meaning of a sentence based on their inclusion or exclusion of the article "a." Understanding how to use these words correctly is crucial for conveying the right amount or quantity.

Quick reference

Countable vs. Uncountable Nouns	Few is used with countable nouns.
Countable vs. Uncountable Nouns	Apples, books, opportunities, cars.
Countable vs. Uncountable Nouns	Water, money, advice, information.

Key Points

Countable vs. Uncountable Nouns

- Few is used with countable nouns.
- Little is used with uncountable nouns.

Example of Countable Nouns:

- Apples, books, opportunities, cars.

Example of Uncountable Nouns:

- Water, money, advice, information.

Usage of "Few" and "A Few"

A Few

- Indicates a small number of countable items that is enough for a particular purpose.
- Example Sentences: I have a few friends in the city, so I am not lonely. She brought a few cookies to the party, which was enough for everyone. There are a few seats available, so we can still get tickets for the concert.

Few



- Indicates a small number of countable items that is not enough for a particular purpose.
- Example Sentences: I have few friends in the city, so I feel lonely. She brought few cookies to the party, which was not enough for everyone. There are few seats available, so we might not get tickets for the concert.

Usage of "Little" and "A Little"

A Little

- Indicates a small amount of uncountable items that is enough for a particular purpose.
- Example Sentences: I have a little money, so I can buy lunch today. There is a little water left in the bottle, enough to quench my thirst. She has a little time before the meeting, so she can review her notes.

Little

- Indicates a small amount of uncountable items that is not enough for a particular purpose.
- Example Sentences: I have little money, so I cannot buy lunch today. There is little water left in the bottle, not enough to quench my thirst. She has little time before the meeting, so she cannot review her notes.

Detailed Examples and Contexts

Countable Nouns

Context: Speaking about job opportunities.

- A Few Opportunities: "I have a few opportunities to speak English, so I am learning faster than I expected." Meaning: There are enough opportunities to help me learn English effectively.
- Few Opportunities: "I have few opportunities to speak English, so I am not learning as fast as I expected." Meaning: There are not enough opportunities to help me learn English effectively.

Uncountable Nouns

Context: Talking about cash or money.

- A Little Cash: "I have a little cash, so I can buy lunch today." Meaning: The amount of cash I have is enough for buying lunch.
- Little Cash: "I have little cash, so I cannot buy lunch today." Meaning: The amount of cash I have is not enough for buying lunch.

Grammar Summary

- Use a few with countable nouns to indicate a small but sufficient number.
- Use few with countable nouns to indicate a small and insufficient number.



- Use a little with uncountable nouns to indicate a small but sufficient amount.
- Use little with uncountable nouns to indicate a small and insufficient amount.

Additional Practice

To further solidify understanding, here are more example sentences with varied contexts:

Countable Nouns:

- A Few: "He answered a few questions correctly on the test, so he passed." "They received a few donations, which helped cover the costs."
- Few: "He answered few questions correctly on the test, so he failed." "They received few donations, which were not enough to cover the costs."

Uncountable Nouns:

- A Little: "There is a little sugar in the jar, enough for my coffee." "I have a little information about the topic, so I can participate in the discussion."
- Little: "There is little sugar in the jar, not enough for my coffee." "I have little information about the topic, so I cannot participate in the discussion."

Understanding the correct usage of few, a few, little, and a little is essential for accurate communication in English. Using these words appropriately will help convey the intended meaning and improve overall language proficiency.

Few and Little with/without "a"

Concept Explanation

The words few and little can drastically change the meaning of a sentence based on their inclusion or exclusion of the article "a." Understanding how to use these words correctly is crucial for conveying the right amount or quantity.

Countable vs. Uncountable Nouns

- Few is used with countable nouns.
- Little is used with uncountable nouns.

Examples of Countable Nouns:

- Apples, books, opportunities, cars.

Examples of Uncountable Nouns:

- Water, money, advice, information.



Usage of "Few" and "A Few"

A Few

- Definition: "A few" indicates a small number of countable items that is enough for a particular purpose.
- Examples: "I have a few friends in the city, so I am not lonely." ■ "She brought a few cookies to the party, which was enough for everyone." ■ "There are a few seats available, so we can still get tickets for the concert." ■

Few

- Definition: "Few" indicates a small number of countable items that is not enough for a particular purpose.
- Examples: "I have few friends in the city, so I feel lonely." ■ "She brought few cookies to the party, which was not enough for everyone." ■ "There are few seats available, so we might not get tickets for the concert." ■

Usage of "Little" and "A Little"

A Little

- Definition: "A little" indicates a small amount of uncountable items that is enough for a particular purpose.
- Examples: "I have a little money, so I can buy lunch today." ■ "There is a little water left in the bottle, enough to quench my thirst." ■ "She has a little time before the meeting, so she can review her notes." ■

Little

- Definition: "Little" indicates a small amount of uncountable items that is not enough for a particular purpose.
- Examples: "I have little money, so I cannot buy lunch today." ■ "There is little water left in the bottle, not enough to quench my thirst." ■ "She has little time before the meeting, so she cannot review her notes." ■

Detailed Examples and Contexts

Countable Nouns

Context: Speaking about job opportunities.

- A Few Opportunities: "I have a few opportunities to speak English, so I am learning faster than I expected." ■ Meaning: There are enough opportunities to help me learn English effectively.
- Few Opportunities: "I have few opportunities to speak English, so I am not learning as fast as I expected." ■ Meaning: There are not enough opportunities to help me learn English effectively.

Uncountable Nouns



Context: Talking about cash or money.

- A Little Cash: "I have a little cash, so I can buy lunch today." ■ Meaning: The amount of cash I have is enough for buying lunch.
- Little Cash: "I have little cash, so I cannot buy lunch today." ■ Meaning: The amount of cash I have is not enough for buying lunch.

Grammar Summary

- A Few: Use with countable nouns to indicate a small but sufficient number.
- Few: Use with countable nouns to indicate a small and insufficient number.
- A Little: Use with uncountable nouns to indicate a small but sufficient amount.
- Little: Use with uncountable nouns to indicate a small and insufficient amount.

Additional Practice

To further solidify understanding, here are more example sentences with varied contexts:

Countable Nouns:

- A Few: "He answered a few questions correctly on the test, so he passed." ■ "They received a few donations, which helped cover the costs." ■
- Few: "He answered few questions correctly on the test, so he failed." ■ "They received few donations, which were not enough to cover the costs." ■

Uncountable Nouns:

- A Little: "There is a little sugar in the jar, enough for my coffee." ■ "I have a little information about the topic, so I can participate in the discussion." ■
- Little: "There is little sugar in the jar, not enough for my coffee." ■ "I have little information about the topic, so I cannot participate in the discussion." ■

Understanding the correct usage of few, a few, little, and a little is essential for accurate communication in English. Using these words appropriately will help convey the intended meaning and improve overall language proficiency.



Practice Check

Answer the quiz questions below with responses consistent with the grammar concepts taught in this article.

ITEM 01

I have _____ friends in the city, so I am not lonely.

a) few

b) a few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 02

There is _____ water left in the bottle, not enough to quench my thirst.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 03

She has _____ money, so she can buy lunch today.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 04

He answered _____ questions correctly on the test, so he passed.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 05**

I have _____ opportunities to speak English, so I am learning faster than I expected.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 06

There are _____ seats available, so we might not get tickets for the concert.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 07

I have _____ opportunities to speak English, so I am not learning as fast as I expected.

a) few

b) a few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 08

I have _____ cash, so I cannot buy lunch today.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 09**

I have _____ money, so I cannot buy lunch today.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 10

She has _____ friends, so she feels lonely.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 11

She brought _____ cookies to the party, which was not enough for everyone.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 12

She brought _____ cookies to the party, which was enough for everyone.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 13**

There is _____ information available to make a decision.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 14

There is _____ water in the glass, enough to fill the cup.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 15

There is _____ milk in the fridge, not enough for cereal.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 16

She has _____ patience left after dealing with the kids all day.

a) little

b) a little

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 17**

He gave _____ effort in the project, resulting in poor outcomes.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 18

He put in _____ effort in the project, leading to its success.

a) little

b) a little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 19

He gave _____ of his time to help with the project, which was appreciated.

a) a little

b) little

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 20

There are _____ apples in the basket, not enough for everyone.

a) a few

b) few

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 21**

There are _____ apples in the basket, enough for everyone.

a) few

b) a few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 22

He received _____ invitations, so he is not sure which party to attend.

a) few

b) a few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 23

He received _____ invitations, so he is sure which party to attend.

a) few

b) a few

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 24

He has _____ friends to help him move, so he is worried.

a) few

b) a few

Correct choice: _____



Self-check Answer Key

Use the key after you have completed every item on your own.

ITEM 01

I have a few friends in the city, so I am not lonely.

ITEM 02

There is little water left in the bottle, not enough to quench my thirst.

ITEM 03

She has a little money, so she can buy lunch today.

ITEM 04

He answered a few questions correctly on the test, so he passed.

ITEM 05

I have a few opportunities to speak English, so I am learning faster than I expected.

ITEM 06

There are few seats available, so we might not get tickets for the concert.

ITEM 07

I have few opportunities to speak English, so I am not learning as fast as I expected.

ITEM 08

I have little cash, so I cannot buy lunch today.

ITEM 09

I have little money, so I cannot buy lunch today.

ITEM 10

She has few friends, so she feels lonely.

ITEM 11

She brought few cookies to the party, which was not enough for everyone.

ITEM 12

She brought a few cookies to the party, which was enough for everyone.

ITEM 13

There is little information available to make a decision.

ITEM 14

There is a little water in the glass, enough to fill the cup.



ITEM 15

There is little milk in the fridge, not enough for cereal.

ITEM 16

She has little patience left after dealing with the kids all day.

ITEM 17

He gave little effort in the project, resulting in poor outcomes.

ITEM 18

He put in a little effort in the project, leading to its success.

ITEM 19

He gave a little of his time to help with the project, which was appreciated.

ITEM 20

There are few apples in the basket, not enough for everyone.

ITEM 21

There are a few apples in the basket, enough for everyone.

ITEM 22

He received a few invitations, so he is not sure which party to attend.

ITEM 23

He received few invitations, so he is sure which party to attend.

ITEM 24

He has few friends to help him move, so he is worried.